

It's the PKL decade

While the Pro Kabaddi League has undoubtedly flourished amidst glitz and glamour over the past decade, the sport itself **yearns for the extra punch it rightfully deserves**.

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Atenth season is a great time to pause and take stock of where a franchise league is headed. More so when you're among the top three most popular tournaments in a country as sports-crazy as India.

Towards that end, Puneri Paltan's maiden title triumph neatly ties up, with a bow, everything right with the concept of a franchise-based league for a sport as raw and ancient as kabaddi. It was the triumph of an academy system that has been scouting and moulding talent season after season, no matter the eventual outcome.

Coaches came and went, superstar players made pit stops here in their PKL career journeys, but the budding young talent pool stayed the same, playing in youth leagues and earning their stripes to make the playing 7s in PKL. All that hard work and an unwavering faith in the team has brought the ultimate prize: validation in the form of the league crown.

Thanks to a squad stacked with all-rounders, Puneri Paltan had a team where everyone could do almost anything. The players came at opponents in waves. If an Aslam Inamdar, the franchise's lead raider and captain, was sent to the bench, in came a Mohit Goyat or a Pankaj Mohite or an Akash Shinde — all academy exports. Defenders could raid, raiders could defend and the Pune side of the mat was never really

in a tight spot for too long for most part of the season.

Defensive powerhouse Mohammadreza Shadloui Chiyaneh, who has cemented his place as Fazel Atrachali's successor as the next big thing in Iranian kabaddi, put on a show that well deserves the moniker of 'The Showman', a title long associated with Indian superstar, Rahul Chaudhari. There was no dull moment with Puneri Paltan on court, no matter how brittle the opponent, and that prompted plenty of superlatives on whether this team is the greatest in the league's history.

While those arguments will need consistency over a few seasons to be defended or refuted, it's the glossy gold-plated cover over a season that was disappointingly lopsided. Strong teams got stronger, while the weak ones dipped further into the abyss. Telugu Titans, a side where Chaudhari and others like Siddharth Desai captured the imagination of audiences and pushed the peripheries of possibility in the sport, has looked a pale shadow of its former self. Even the presence of the Indian captain Pawan Sehrawat, who, with 202 raid points and a largely lone-wolf effort, could not salvage much joy for his team and its fans.

Tamil Thalaivas showed sparks of the resilience that carried it to the playoffs last season but fell flat towards the business end. Bengal Warriors, UP Yoddhas and Bengaluru Bulls have unfortunately backed themselves into their own versions of a rut, with their season's takeaways largely looking similar to editions

past. The areas of improvement remain the same, the solutions glaringly obvious. Much of it can be sorted with a mega auction that'll give teams a fresh chance to rethink their playing identities and the brand of the kabaddi they want to champion going forward.

Ripples in the national scene

Anupam Goswami, league commissioner of Pro Kabaddi, prefers to be pragmatic in celebrating the decade gone by.

"It is momentous, yes, but there is a sober realisation that we're still in the nascent stage, as are most other sports leagues in India, in our journey. If we get past the 20-year stage and successfully, then we can sit back and with some satisfaction," he tells *Sportstar*.

Alongside the advancement of talent in the league, the ever improving stats of the players and the eyeballs the league is drawing, Goswami underlines the league's reputation as the biggest feeder line for the national men's team.

"In order to sustain this, the pipeline of talent needs to be promising — not just domestic but also international. In that aspect, the grooming of domestic talent has been one of the biggest successes of the league," he explains. "The future of Indian kabaddi is secured for several years to come thanks to the talents we've brought into this league with the New Young Players programme. It has helped address and debunk the myth that good players come only from one region.